International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing
Int. J. Nonprofit Volunt. Sect. Mark. **18**: 203–215 (2013)
Published online 16 May 2013 in Wiley Online Library
(wileyonlinelibrary.com) **DOI**: 10.1002/nvsm.1468

Charity brand personality: can smaller charitable organizations leverage their brand's personality to influence giving

Elizabeth Stebbins and Rosanne L. Hartman[†*]
Department of Communication Studies, Canisius College, USA

• *The importance of establishing a strong brand identity has been the focus for consumer brand managers for decades. Organizations develop and communicate a distinctive brand personality as a means of attracting consumers and cultivating long-term relationships. While the concept of branding has gained recent attention as an important strategy for nonprofit practitioners, little empirical data exist on the role a charity's brand personality might play in attracting donors. A few recent studies of large national charitable organizations provide support that charities exhibit distinctive personalities. This study explores whether smaller, local scope charitable organizations, without the benefit of national brand recognition, also exhibit distinctive brand personalities and whether such brand personalities influence donors. Results from five charitable organizations, from four distinct categories of cause, find that brand personality traits that are both differentiating and relevant to donors influence charitable giving. The findings provide nonprofit practitioners with valuable insights for leveraging their brand's personality to turn donor awareness into commitment and establish a stronger market position.*

Introduction

In a sector where 1.5 million organizations (National Center for Charitable Statistics, 2012) compete for limited resources, the need for charities to differentiate themselves to capture donor attention and contributions is becoming increasingly important (Barman, 2002; Anctil, 2008). Over the last four decades, the number of nonprofit organizations in the USA has grown from 300 000 in 1967 to 1.5 million in 2011; however, available resources have not grown at a similar rate (National Center for Charitable Statistics, 2012). Resource acquisition in a crowded marketplace has added distraction and expense to nonprofit organizations; effective strategies to increase the number and size of donations are of particular relevance to charity brand managers (Froelich, 1999; McKinley-Floyd and Shrestha, 2008).

*Correspondence to: Rosanne L. Hartman, Department of Communication Studies, Canisius College, 2001 Main St., Buffalo, New York 14208-1098, USA.
E-mail: hartmanr@canisius.edu
[†]Doctor of Philosophy.

A charity's brand may serve to differentiate a charity from competitors and influence giving (Venable *et al*., 2005; Sargeant *et al*., 2008). Because the benefits of becoming involved with a charity are largely intangible, branding can facilitate a donor's understanding and support of a charity and can build cohesion and capacity internal to the organization (Sargeant, 1999; Kylander and Stone, 2012). The importance of establishing a strong brand identity has been the focus for consumer brand managers for decades; consumer brands with strong personalities are associated with high levels of usage and preference (Sirgy, 1982; Freling and Forbes, 2005); strong and differentiated brands significantly enhance firm performance (Madden *et al*., 2006; Colucci *et al*., 2008).

Aaker and Fournier (1995) define brand personality as "The set of human characteristics associated with a brand" (p. 393). Aaker (1997), drawing on earlier studies of human personality, identifies five dimensions of brand personality for consumer brands, namely sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication, and ruggedness. Venable *et al*. (2005) extend Aaker's (1997) conceptualization and measurement of consumer brand personality to the nonprofit sector, finding that charity brands have human personality traits such as their commercial counterparts, although structured differently. Not for profit organizations possess brand characteristics that differ from for profit organizations (Khan and Ede, 2009). Sargeant *et al*. (2008) argue that the picture is more complex: some personality dimensions are shared by the nonprofit sector as a whole, whereas others serve to clearly differentiate and link to charitable giving.

Given the limited empirical data available on charity brand personality and its role in influencing donors (Kylander and Stone, 2012), and the growing popularity in marketing literature advocating the adoption of for- profit branding strategies by nonprofit practitioners (Khan and Ede, 2009; Apaydin, 2011), the topic warrants further research. Additionally, since prior studies used large, well know, national charities, it may be of value to explore whether their findings are transferrable to smaller, local scope charities without the benefit of national brand recognition. Because three-fourths of the nation's 1.5 million charitable organizations are small according to Internal Revenue Service standards, defined as annual operating expenses under $500 000 (Roeger *et al*., 2011), this information could provide many nonprofit practitioners with valuable insights for leveraging their brand's personality to turn donor awareness into commitment and establish a stronger market position. The purpose of this study is to further explore the concept of charity brand personality and its relationship to giving behavior, in the context of smaller, local scope charitable organizations. To begin, a brief review of the extant literature on charitable giving and brand personality is provided.

Charitable giving

In the USA, total giving to the nonprofit sector in 2010 reached $298bn, up 2% from 2009, and equates to 5.4% of gross domestic product, despite the worst economic climate since the Great Depression (Urban Institute Foundation, 2011). Americans donate 2% of their income, on average, to charities; individual giving accounts for 73% of total charitable contributions (Giving USA, 2012). Why donors choose to provide charitable support is a subject that has been studied for decades; however, most research has focused on the characteristics of givers, distinguishing givers from nongivers (Radley and Kennedy, 1995), high value givers from low value givers (Jones and Posnett, 1991), and on donors' motives for giving (Kottasz, 2004).

Donors' perceptions of charities affect giving behavior. For example, donors are more likely to donate when they perceive a charity as contributing value to society (Sargeant *et al*., 2004); when they have the desire to make a difference (Sargeant and Woodliffe, 2007); civic responsibility, egotism, progressivism, and scientific problem solving

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

(Boris, 1987); and for the amelioration of suffering as well as to effect longer term improvements (Radley and Kennedy, 1995). Others have studied the relationship between a donor's self-image and their perception of a charity, finding that individuals are more likely to help those that are perceived as being similar to them (Coliazzi *et al*., 1984; Sargeant and Woodliffe, 2007). Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007) argue that donors may rely almost entirely on their perception of the organization in deciding to offer a donation, particularly in less personal forms of fundraising such as direct mail, press, or radio advertising.

The strategic frameworks for understanding nonprofit sector branding are not fully developed in ways that create useful tools for managers (Kylander and Stone, 2012). To date, most of the research on charitable giving has focused on the role of the donor with little attention paid to a charity's brand and the role it might play in attracting support.

Brand personality

Branding and the concept of brand personality have been studied for decades in the for- profit context (Allison and Uhl, 1964; Valenzi and Andrews, 1971; Sirgy, 1982; Aaker and Fournier, 1995; Freling and Forbes, 2005; Madden *et al*., 2006; Colucci *et al*., 2008). Brand managers of consumer goods focus on branding as a means of attracting consumers and gaining market share; organizations develop and communicate distinctive personalities through their brand (Grounds, 2005). The key to successful branding is to clearly articulate product differences and characteristics and make them real and tangible in consumers' minds (Johnson and Sallee, 1994). Consumer brands with strong personalities are associated with high levels of usage and preference (Sirgy, 1982; Freling and Forbes, 2005) and strong and differentiated brands significantly enhance firm performance (Madden *et al*., 2006; Colucci *et al*., 2008).

Explanations for these brand effects have been the focus of much research. Freling and Forbes (2005) cite the natural tendency of humans to anthropomorphize nonhuman objects to explain why consumers embrace brands with strong, positive personalities; thinking of a nonhuman entity such as a brand in a human way renders it worthy of moral care and consideration. Keller (1993) explores the relationship between consumer personality and brand personality and finds brand personality tends to serve a symbolic or self-expressive function for consumers, in contrast to product-related attributes, which serve a more utilitarian function. Several studies (Aaker and Fournier, 1995; De Chernatony *et al*., 2004; Mulyanegara *et al*., 2009) explore the relationship between self-concept and brands used and find consumers have preferences for brands they perceive as having a personality congruent with their own values and personalities.

Researchers have extended the concepts and principles of attribution theory to understanding consumer behavior (Jones and Davis, 1965; Kelley, 1967). When a consumer is faced with the problem of evaluating the worth of a product that he cannot possibly objectively evaluate from physical characteristics alone, the consumer will turn to other items of information, including price, brand, and the behavior of others (Valenzi and Andrews, 1971). Impressions formed about the source of a message can influence the acceptability of the message (Frymier and Nadler, 2007).

The concept of branding has gained recent attention in the nonprofit sector (Brand Channel, 2007; Khan and Ede, 2009), and with no tangible product to sell, branding is critically important for nonprofit organizations (Brand Strategy, 2006). Few studies have addressed the dimensions of charity brands or the relationship between charity brand personality and individual giving behavior. Venable *et al*. (2005) extend the conceptualization and measurement of brand personality to the nonprofit sector. The authors conducted a series of six multidimensional studies on stakeholders of

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

nonprofit organizations that were well-known and national in scope and identified four dimensions of charity brand personality: integrity, nurturance, sophistication, and ruggedness. Some commonalties with Aaker's (1997) five dimensions of brand personality for consumer brands were found (sophistication and ruggedness); however, two new dimensions emerged (integrity and nurturance). The authors further conclude that brand personality may influence potential donors' giving behavior.

Sargeant *et al*. (2008) further the work of Venable *et al*. (2005) by studying whether charity brand personality traits are distinctive or shared with others in the sector, and whether there is a relationship between these traits and donors' giving behavior. From a study of 9000 individual donors of nine well-known national charities in the UK, the authors constructed a framework of seven dimensions of brand personality for charities; they found that only traits pertaining to the dimensions of "emotional engagement", "service", "voice", and "tradition" are capable of distinguishing between organizations, whereas traits pertaining to the dimensions of "benevolence", "progression", and "conservatism" appear to transcend the sector. They further conclude that only "voice" and "emotional engagement" are linked to charitable giving behavior; therefore, greater utility can be derived by promoting the personality dimensions that are genuinely distinctive rather than focusing on those traits that are shared across the sector.

Using the brand personality framework developed by Sargeant *et al*. (2008), the authors seek to replicate previous findings in the context of smaller, local scope charitable organizations without the benefit of national brand recognition. The study will also determine whether such organizations exhibit distinctive brand personalities that can serve to differentiate in a crowded marketplace and whether such brand personalities influence giving behavior. Three research questions arise:

- RQ1: Do smaller, local scope charitable organizations exhibit distinct brand personalities?
- RQ2: Can distinctive charity brand personalities serve to differentiate in a crowded marketplace?
- RQ3: What is the relationship between donors' perceptions of a charity's brand personality and giving behavior?

Method

To address the research questions, an exploratory, quantitative study was conducted using a nonrandom, convenience sample and a self-administered, anonymous survey design. Institutional Review Board approval was obtained prior to conducting the study.

Procedures

Data were collected on brand personality perceptions and giving behavior using a subject pool of current donors to five charitable organizations in a large northeastern city in the USA. The five charitable organizations represent four distinct categories of cause (social welfare, environment and/or animal, health care, and arts/cultural) to optimize diversity in traits exhibited. All of the organizations are local in scope, and four of the five have no national brand recognition; the fifth organization is a local chapter of a national organization. Of the 1011 respondents who completed the survey, Charity A had 146 respondents (response rate 6.1%), Charity B had 165 respondents (response rate 9.7%), Charity C had 100 respondents (response rate 20%), Charity D had 75 respondents (response rate 10.7%), and Charity E had 624 respondents (response rate 9.8%) for an overall response rate from the five charity organizations of 9.5%.

Participants were recruited from the donor databases of each of the five charitable organizations to complete a self-administered, anonymous, electronic survey. To limit the effects of this mode of administration on sample size, only those organizations with email addresses for the majority of their donors and experience communicating with donors electronically were invited to participate in the study. Donors

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

were made aware of the survey through a mass email distribution to all donors for whom participating charities had current email addresses; participation was on a voluntary basis. The email was sent by each charitable organization explaining the purpose of the study and requesting that people participate. Respondents were asked to answer questions for the specific charity they currently support. As a general qualifier, respondents were asked their level of contributions (money, time, and in-kind goods or services) to nonprofit organizations within the previous 24 months; options ranged from *none* to *a lot*. Respondents were then asked to describe the brand personality of the charity and provide a self-report of their own giving behavior towards that charity. Current donors were defined as those who provided some form of support to the charity within the most recent 24 months.

Survey instrument

The measure of brand personality was based on the framework of charity brand personality dimensions developed by Sargeant *et al*. (2008) where seven dimensions of charity brand personality with 34 subtypes of personality traits were identified. The survey instrument used in this study included the 34 traits attributed to charity brands by donors in the Sargeant *et al*. (2008) study. Respondents were asked to evaluate the extent to which each of the 34 human personality traits describes the charitable organization they support on a Likert scale from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*). For example, a question was posed, “Think of your charity as if it were a person. How would you describe its personality?” Personality traits measured by the survey can be found in **Table 1**.

Reliability

Construct reliability estimates were calculated for the 34-trait brand personality scale and for each of the seven brand personality dimensions. A coefficient alpha reliability estimate of 0.97 was attained for the 34-trait scale, an acceptable level. Subscale alphas for brand personality dimensions ranged from 0.74 to 0.96. Specifically, *benevolence* included 14 items, with an alpha coefficient of 0.96; *progression* included five items, with an alpha coefficient of 0.88; *conservatism* included two items, with an alpha coefficient of 0.77; *emotional engagement* included six items with an alpha coefficient of 0.88; *voice* included three items, with an alpha coefficient of 0.74; and *service* included three items, with an alpha coefficient of 0.79. The dimension *tradition* was measured with only one item.

Other measures were included in the survey instrument to identify giving behavior in terms of *amount given, share of charitable pot*, and *likelihood to contribute*.

Participants

The respondents were largely women (80.5%), Caucasian (96.3%), between the ages of 45 and 64 (57.5%) and educated (59.6% possessed a 4-year college degree or higher). Of those that responded, 26.3% reported household incomes between \$25 000 and \$49 999, 24.4% between \$50 000 and \$74 999, 15.9% between \$75 000 and \$99 999, and 16% between \$100 000 and \$149 999. Only 9.7% reported incomes below \$25 000 and 7.6% over \$150 000. The sample exhibited high levels of experience or current involvement with charitable organizations (98.3%), as evidenced by the high percentages of respondents who reported contributing money, time, or in-kind goods or services in the most recent 24 months.

The charitable organizations in the study did not collect data on the ethnicity, age, education, or income of their donors, not uncommon for small not for profit organizations. Therefore, it is unknown how the respondents’ profiles align with the overall donor profiles of the organizations studied. The greater response rate by women in this study is not surprising, as numerous studies show women are more likely than men to support nonprofit organizations both in terms of giving and volunteering time (Havens *et al*., 2006; Themudo, 2009).

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

Table 1. Comparison means of brand traits for five charities

Dimension	Trait	Charity A	Charity B	Charity C	Charity D	Charity E	Total mean	Standard deviation
Benevolence	Caring	6.47	5.81	6.80	6.69	6.77	6.58	0.79
	Ethical	6.34	6.01	6.73	6.44	6.60	6.48	0.85
	Fair	6.16	5.82	6.46	6.23	6.40	6.28	0.95
	Focused	6.38	5.98	6.36	6.19	6.51	6.38	0.95
	Helpful	6.40	5.92	6.65	6.55	6.55	6.44	0.77
	Honest	6.23	6.00	6.59	6.28	6.46	6.36	0.84
	Practical	6.12	5.86	6.27	6.07	6.30	6.19	0.94
	Reputable	6.49	6.27	6.58	6.28	6.62	6.52	0.66
	Respectful	6.34	5.78	6.60	6.49	6.40	6.32	0.90
	Responsible	6.28	6.15	6.53	6.32	6.57	6.45	0.71
	Supportive	6.38	5.66	6.75	6.56	6.45	6.36	0.91
	Sympathetic	6.36	4.92	6.47	6.49	6.63	6.32	1.09
	Thoughtful	6.28	5.57	6.43	6.36	6.32	6.22	0.96
	Trustworthy	6.30	5.88	6.56	6.33	6.48	6.36	0.85
Progression	Empowering	6.03	5.15	6.50	6.24	5.92	5.89	1.38
	Engaging	5.94	5.78	6.11	5.99	6.08	6.01	1.14
	Pioneering	6.05	5.31	6.29	6.29	5.83	5.85	1.13
	Transforming	5.76	5.32	6.49	6.23	5.91	5.88	1.36
	Visionary	5.86	5.45	6.31	6.07	5.91	5.88	1.15
Conservatism	Cautious	5.38	5.05	5.22	5.20	5.68	5.47	1.65
	Conservative	5.47	5.41	4.95	4.50	5.55	5.39	1.80
Emotional engagement	Exciting	5.58	5.64	6.00	5.67	5.87	5.79	1.12
	Fun	5.41	6.01	4.97	4.61	6.02	5.75	1.55
	Heroic	5.77	4.52	5.92	6.09	6.43	5.99	1.62
	Inspiring	5.84	5.38	6.05	6.07	5.90	5.84	1.34
	Innovative	6.15	5.90	6.61	6.27	6.36	6.28	1.06
	Modern	5.87	5.15	5.65	5.84	5.87	5.74	1.39
Voice	Ambitious	6.14	5.48	6.08	6.09	6.22	6.08	1.19
	Authoritative	5.82	5.19	5.29	5.08	5.86	5.65	1.68
	Bold	5.53	5.13	6.19	5.77	5.67	6.63	1.19
Service	Approachable	6.14	5.96	6.15	6.03	6.27	6.18	1.09
	Compassionate	6.43	5.20	6.79	6.68	6.74	6.47	0.93
	Dedicated	6.51	6.27	6.73	6.61	6.72	6.62	0.54
Tradition	Traditional	5.90	5.82	4.79	4.31	5.79	5.62	1.51

Results

Personality distinctiveness

The measures used were intended to identify the personalities of charitable organizations. Descriptive statistics were used to assess whether charity brand personalities are distinctive for each of the five organizations in the study. First, mean scores and standard deviations were calculated for all 34 personality traits (**Table 1**) and for each of the seven personality dimensions (**Table 2**).

Results indicate that the five organizations do exhibit distinct personalities. Overall, participants perceive Charity A as the most tradition*al* ($m = 5.90$) of the five, Charity C as the most *benevolent* ($m = 6.56$) and *progressive* ($m = 6.34$), and Charity E the most *emotionally engaging* ($m = 6.08$). Within charities, Charity B's strongest dimension is

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

Table 2. Comparison means of brand personality dimensions for five charities

Personality Dimension	Charity A	Charity B	Charity C	Charity D	Charity E	Total mean	Standard deviation
Benevolence	6.32	5.83	6.56	6.34	6.50	6.38	0.75
Service	6.36	5.81	6.55	6.44	6.58	6.43	0.78
Tradition	5.90	5.82	4.79	4.31	5.79	5.62	1.22
Conservatism	5.42	5.23	5.09	4.85	5.62	5.43	1.19
Emotional Engagement	5.77	5.43	5.87	5.76	6.08	5.90	0.92
Voice	5.83	5.27	5.85	5.65	5.92	5.79	0.97
Progression	5.93	5.40	6.34	6.16	5.93	5.90	0.96

benevolence (*m* = *5.83*), whereas Charity D's is service (*m* = *6.44*). Even within dimensions, differences can be observed that more clearly define each organization's unique personality; within the dimension emotional engagement, Charity B is perceived as most *fun* (*m* = *6.01*), whereas Charity C is perceived as most *exciting* (*m* = *6.00*), Charity E most *heroic* (*m* = *6.43*), Charity D most *inspiring* (*m* = *6.07*), and Charity A most *modern* (*m* = *5.87*). While the means tell us there are differences in the personalities among the organizations, we do not know if the differences are significant; this will be addressed later in discussion and implications.

Next, mean differences from the grand mean were calculated for each brand dimension and displayed graphically to see how brand personality dimensions may vary across the five organizations (**Figure 1**). Results indicate that some personality

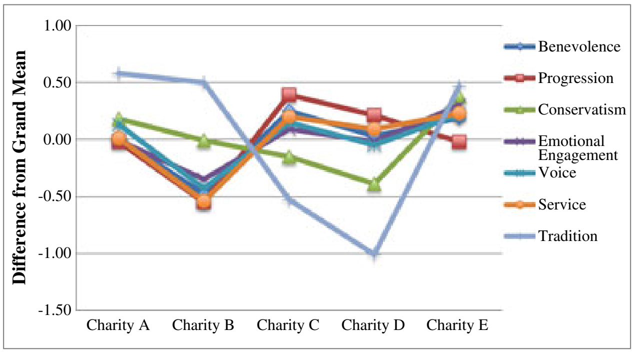

Figure 1. Mean differences from grand mean for five charities.

dimensions vary more across the sector than others; tradition (*sd* = *1.22*) and conservatism (*sd* = *1.19*) show the highest amount of variability, whereas benevolence (*sd* = 0.*75*) and service (*sd* = 0.*78*) show the least. While the standard deviations tell us that some personality dimensions vary more than others, we do not know if the differences are significant; this will be addressed later in discussion and implications.

Personality differentiation

The second question seeks to determine whether distinctive personalities can serve to differentiate a charity in a crowded marketplace. An important consideration may be whether or not these personality dimensions have relevance for donors; both relevance and differentiation are considered necessary for brand personality to create consumer value in the for profit sector (Batra and Homer, 2004).

Figure 2 plots the means of the seven personality dimensions for each charity on the rating scale. The figure shows that benevolence and service are the highest rated (*agree to strongly agree*) brand dimensions across all five charities but are also the two dimensions with the least amount of variability across the five charities, suggesting that benevolence and service are relevant to donors but cannot serve to differentiate. Tradition and conservatism have the highest amount of variability across the five charities; however, neither dimension achieves a rating higher than *somewhat agrees* for any of the

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

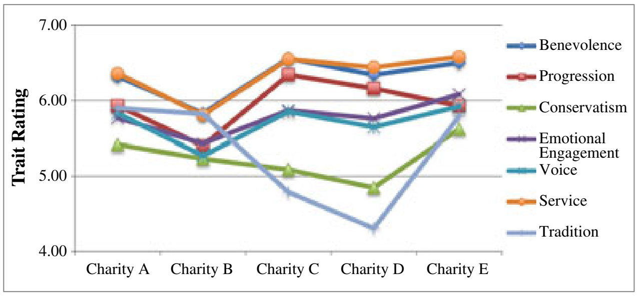

Figure 2. Brand dimension ratings for five charities.

organizations, suggesting that while tradition and conservatism may serve to differentiate a charity, these dimensions do not have relevance for donors. Only the dimensions emotional engagement, progression, and voice, with means varying across the five organizations and scores between *somewhat agree* and *strongly agree*, appear to have both relevance and can serve to differentiate a charity in a crowded marketplace.

Predictive validity

A further intent of the study was to examine the relationship between respondents' perceptions of a charitable organization's brand personality and giving behavior. Spearman's *rho* correlation coefficients were calculated to analyze the relationship between each of the seven brand personality dimensions and three giving behaviors (**Table 3**).

The results indicate that the relationship between each brand personality dimension and *likelihood to contribute* is direct and moderate, with the exception of conservatism and tradition (both weak); correlations are 0.392 for benevolence, 0.374 for service, 0.339 for emotional engagement, 0.289 for progression, 0.286 for voice, 0.142 for tradition, and 0.128 for conservatism; all correlation coefficients were significant at $p < 0.01$. The relationship between each personality dimension and *amount given* is direct and weak, with the exception of tradition (not significant); correlations are 0.217 for voice, 0.207 for emotional engagement, 0.205 for benevolence, 0.196 for service, 0.193 for progression, 0.105 for conservatism, and 0.052 for tradition; all correlation coefficients were significant at $p < 0.01$, with the exception of tradition. And the relationship between each personality dimension and *share of charitable pot* is direct and weak, with the exception of emotional engagement (moderate); correlations are 0.252 for emotional engagement, 0.224 for service, 0.202 for voice, 0.190 for benevolence, 0.164 for progression, 0.154 for conservatism, and 0.126 for tradition; all correlation coefficients were significant at $p < 0.01$.

From the data, it appears that there is a relationship between respondents' perceptions of a charity's brand personality and giving behavior. Additionally, brand personality dimensions that are both relevant to donors and can serve to differentiate an organization (emotional engagement, voice, and progression) have stronger relationships with giving behavior than those dimensions that are not relevant to donors (tradition and conservatism).

Discussion and implications

The study attempts to validate previous research on charity brand personality (Sargeant *et al.*, 2008), in the context of smaller, local scope charities without the benefit of national brand recognition. The results provide support that these charities have distinctive brand personalities, certain brand personality dimensions (emotional engagement, voice, and progression) are both relevant and differentiating, and a direct relationship exists between donors' perceptions of a charity's brand personality and giving behavior, with more relevant and differentiating brand personality dimensions exhibiting stronger relationships.

The results confirmed previous findings that some charity brand personality dimensions transcend the nonprofit sector, whereas others can serve to differentiate; however, some differences emerged. Sargeant *et al.* (2008) found that the brand personality dimensions benevolence, progression, and conservatism transcend the nonprofit sector,

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

Table 3. Correlation coefficients: brand personality dimensions and giving behavior

Correlations												
Spearman's rho		Conservatism	Progression	Benevolence	Emotional Engagement	Voice	Service	Tradition	Amount Given	Share of Wallet	Length of Time Giving	Likelihood to Contribute
Conservatism	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	0.422**	0.475**	0.484**	0.530**	0.373**	0.573**	0.105**	0.154**	0.044	0.128**
	Sig. (2-tailed)		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.144	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Progression	Correlation Coefficient	0.422**	1.000	0.745**	0.853**	0.787**	0.675**	0.319**	0.193**	0.164**	0.070*	0.289**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.020	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Benevolence	Correlation Coefficient	0.475**	0.745**	1.000	0.755**	0.680**	0.827**	0.404**	0.205**	0.190**	0.134**	0.392**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Emotional Engagement	Correlation Coefficient	0.484**	0.853**	0.755**	1.000	0.793**	0.715**	0.412**	0.207**	0.252**	0.104**	0.339**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.001	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Voice	Correlation Coefficient	0.530**	0.787**	0.680**	0.793**	1.000	0.608**	0.427**	0.217**	0.202**	0.105**	0.286**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Service	Correlation Coefficient	0.373**	0.675**	0.827**	0.715**	0.608**	1.000	0.313**	0.196**	0.224**	0.124**	0.374**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000		0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Tradition	Correlation Coefficient	0.573**	0.319**	0.404**	0.412**	0.427**	0.313**	1.000	0.052	0.126**	0.085**	0.142**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000		0.082	0.000	0.005	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Amount Given	Correlation Coefficient	0.105**	0.193**	0.205**	0.207**	0.217**	0.196**	0.052	1.000	0.427**	0.345**	0.402**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.082		0.000	0.000	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Share of Wallet	Correlation Coefficient	0.154**	0.164**	0.190**	0.252**	0.202**	0.224**	0.126**	0.427**	1.000	0.200**	0.349**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000		0.000	0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Length of Time Giving	Correlation Coefficient	0.044	0.070*	0.134**	0.104**	0.105**	0.124**	0.085**	0.345**	0.200**	1.000	0.320**

(*Continues*)

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

Table 3. (Continued)

Spearman's rho		Conservatism	Progression	Benevolence	Emotional Engagement	Voice	Service	Tradition	Amount Given	Share of Wallet	Length of Time Giving	Likelihood to Contribute
						Correlations						
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.144	0.020	0.000	0.001	0.000	0.000	0.005	0.000	0.000		0.000
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110
Likelihood to Contribute	Correlation Coefficient	0.128**	0.289**	0.392**	0.339**	0.288**	0.374**	0.142**	0.402**	0.349**	0.320**	1.000
	Sig. (2-tailed)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	
	N	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110	1110

**Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).
*Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).

whereas emotional engagement, voice, service, and tradition can serve to differentiate. The current study found that only the dimensions benevolence and service transcend the nonprofit sector, whereas emotional engagement, voice, progression, tradition, and conservatism vary across the sector. Furthermore, trait relevance emerged as an additional criterion to consider in evaluating brand personality dimensions and their ability to differentiate; in the current study both conservatism and tradition were found to have little relevance to responders across all five organizations, whereas emotional engagement, voice, and progression were found to have relevance and could serve to differentiate. The differences in results may be attributable to national/cultural differences between donors in the UK, where the Sargeant *et al*. (2008) study was conducted, and US donors; however, it was not the intent of this study to explore cultural differences therefore further research is required to determine the cause of the differences.

Finally, the results build on previous studies regarding the ability of charity brand personality to influence giving behavior (Venable *et al*., 2005; Sargeant *et al*., 2008). Across the five charitable organizations, significant correlations were found between the dimensions of charity brand personality and giving behavior, with more relevant and differentiating personality dimensions (emotional engagement, voice, and progression) exhibiting stronger relationships.

Several limitations are identified and may suggest avenues for future research. Data used in the study were from a nonrandom convenience sample of current donors, and respondents were limited to only those for whom the charities had current email addresses; the generalizability of the results is thus limited. Further, the electronic mode of administration may have limited the number of donors who actually received the survey because of spam or other email security filters.

The charitable organizations in the study did not have data on the ethnicity, age, education, or income of their donors; due in part to the sensitive

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

nature of this information so that most donors are not willing to provide it and that smaller not for profits do not collect this information. Therefore it is unknown how the respondents' profiles align with the overall donor profiles of the organizations studied.

Future research might also explore whether an organization's internal stakeholders hold the same perception of the organization's brand personality as external stakeholders, or whether a respondent's level of involvement with the charity influences their perception of the charity's brand personality.

Only five charities were included in the sample; additional insights may be gained by expanding the study to include multiple charities from each category of cause.

Survey design presents additional limitations: All personality trait adjectives used in the survey are not equally relevant to each category of cause, giving behavior was based on respondents' self-report versus actual giving behavior, and the survey did not include respondents' perceptions of organizational effectiveness or value, which may also influence giving behavior. Future research could include these additional measures.

Further regression could be run in future research to determine if there are any significant differences within or across different categories of cause, perhaps providing a more conclusive view of brand personality differentiation.

Further research on how donors form their perceptions of a charity's brand and how the formation of that perception might be influenced could add additional insight. Research to explore the differentiation between brand image and brand personality could provide additional benefits. Finally, further research may be needed to better understand the impact of cultural differences on donors' perceptions of brand personalities and which brand dimensions are valued.

Despite limitations noted, this study extends our existing knowledge of charity brand personalities. The findings provide nonprofit practitioners, even those from smaller, local scope organizations without the marketing budgets or brand recognition of their national colleagues, with valuable insights for leveraging their brand's unique and relevant personality traits to turn donor awareness into commitment and establish a stronger market position.

Just as consumer product brand managers have known for decades, an organization's brand can play a major role in attracting supporters. A charity's mission and impact are still very important in attracting and retaining support, just as the perceptions of quality and value are for consumer goods. However, brand personality may also be used to turn donor awareness into greater commitment.

Some of the nation's largest charitable organizations have well-recognized brands after decades of hard work and national marketing campaigns that have helped them become household names. Smaller, local scope charitable organizations, without the marketing budgets of their national colleagues, can also leverage the power of their brand. The greatest opportunity lies in identifying and understanding the distinctive and relevant traits that define the brand's personality.

Brand managers can start by defining which traits of emotional engagement (exciting, fun, heroic, and inspiring); voice (ambitious, authoritative, and bold); or progression (empowering, pioneering, and transforming) most closely align with the organization's mission and identity. Ask key stakeholders and long-term supporters of the organization to identify which personality traits they attribute to the organization. An understanding of what attracts current supporters to the organization can be leveraged to gain the attention of would-be supporters.

All communications should project a unique brand personality that resonates with supporters and differentiates the organization from others competing for the same pool of donations. An organization may need to retool its marketing strategy and materials so its unique brand personality connects on an emotional level with supporters and facilitates their understanding of what the organization is really about. An organization may be helpful, caring, and compassionate (benevolence traits), but these

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

traits apply to most charitable organizations, and marketing them will not help achieve a unique position in a donor's mind. Once the brand personality is clearly defined, the organization should be focused on delivering that message at every touch point with the public. Performance will be greater for nonprofit organizations pursuing an integrated brand orientation approach (Apaydin, 2011).

Brand personality also may be a factor when establishing partnerships with corporations for sponsorships or cause-related marketing. By clearly understanding the organization's brand personality, brand managers may be better able to identify those organizations that are a good fit for partnership opportunities.

Because charities must compete for limited resources in a crowded marketplace, an understanding of which personality traits are relevant and differentiating have practical implications. As with consumer products, charitable organizations, even those smaller and local in scope, have distinct identities that may be leveraged to turn donor awareness of their organization into a greater commitment to give.

References

Aaker J. 1997. Dimensions of Brand Personality. *Journal of Marketing Research* **34**(3): 347–356.

Aaker J, Fournier S. 1995. A Brand as a Character, a Partner and a Person: Three Perspectives on the Question of Brand Personality. *Advances in Consumer Research* **22**: 391–395.

Allison RI, Uhl KP. 1964. Influence of Beer Brand Identification on Taste Perception. *Journal of Marketing Research* **1**: 36–39.

Anctil E. 2008. Marketing and Advertising the Intangible. *ASHE Higher Education Report* **3**(2): 31–47.

Apaydin F. 2011. A Proposed Model of Antecedents and Outcomes of Brand Orientation for Nonprofit Sector. *Asian Social Science* **11**: 194–202.

Barman E. 2002. Asserting Difference: The Strategic Response of Nonprofit Organizations to Competition. *Social Forces* **80**(4): 1191–1222.

Batra R, Homer PM. 2004. The Situational Impact of Brand Image Beliefs. *Journal of Consumer Psychology* **14**(3): 318–330.

Boris ET. 1987. The Values of the Wealthy: Philanthropic Attitudes as a Reflection of Political Philosophy in American Culture. *The Constitution and the Independent Sector*. Independent Sector: Washington, DC; 237–247.

Brand Channel. 2007. Retrieved September 9, 2012, from www.brandchannel.com

Brand Strategy. 2006. Non-Profit Branding; Cause and Brand Effect. Centaur Communications Ltd. 2006. Retrieved September 9, 2012, from http://www.highbeam.com/doc/1G1-141736124.html

Coliazzi A, Williams KJ, Kayson WA. 1984. When Will People Help? The Effects of Gender, Urgency and Locations on Altruism. *Psychological Reports* **55**: 139–142.

Colucci M, Montaguti C, Lago U. 2008. Managing Brand Extension via Licensing: An Investigation into the High end Fashion Industry. *International Journal of Research in Marketing* **25**(2): 129–137.

De Chernatony L, Drury S, Segal-Horn S. 2004. Identifying and Sustaining Services Brands' Values. *Journal of Marketing Communications* **10**: 73–94.

Freling T, Forbes L. 2005. An Examination of Brand Personality Through Methodological Triangulation. *Journal of Brand Management* **13**: 148–162.

Froelich K. 1999. Diversification of Revenue Strategies: Evolving Resources Dependence in Nonprofit Organizations. *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly* **28**: 246–268.

Frymier A, Nadler M. 2007. Persuasion: Integrating Theory, Research, and Practice. Kendall/Hunt: Dubuque.

Giving USA Foundation. 2012. Giving USA: The Annual Report for the Year 2011. Retrieved September 10, 2012, from http://www.givingusa.org

Grounds J. 2005. Special Issues on Charity Branding. *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing* **10**: 65–67.

Havens JJ, O'Herlihy MA, Schervish PG. 2006. Charitable giving: How much, by whom, to what, and how. In The Nonprofit Sector: A Research Handbook, 2nd edn, Powell W, Steinberg R (eds). Yale University Press: New Haven, CT; 542–567.

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm

Johnson J, Sallee D. 1994. Marketing Your College as an Intangible Product. *Journal of College Admission* **144**: 16–20.

Jones EE, Davis KE. 1965. From Acts to Dispositions. The Attribution Process in Person Perception, Advances in Experimental Psychology, Vol. **II**. Academic Press: New York.

Jones A, Posnett J. 1991. Charitable Giving by UK Households: Evidence from the Family Expenditure Survey. *Applied Economics* **23**: 343–351.

Keller K. 1993. Conceptualizing, Measuring, and Managing Customer-Based Brand Equity. *Journal of Marketing* **57**: 1–22.

Kelley HH. 1967. Attribution in Social Psychology.-*Nebraska Symposium on Motivation* **15**: 192–238.

Khan H, Ede D. 2009. How do not-for-Profit SMEs Attempt to Develop a Strong Brand in an Increasingly Saturated Market? *Journal of Small Business and Enterprise Development* **16**: 335–354.

Kottasz R. 2004. How Should Charitable Organizations Motivate Young Professionals to Give Philanthropically? *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing* **9**(1): 9–27.

Kylander N, Stone C. 2012. The Role of Brand in the Nonprofit Sector. *Stanford Social Innovation Review* **10**: 36–41.

Madden T, Fehle F, Fournier S. 2006. Brands Matter: An Empirical Demonstration of the Creation of Shareholder Value through Branding. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Sciences* **34**(2): 224–235.

McKinley-Floyd L, Shrestha N. 2008. Segmentation Strategies for Non-Profits: Mining the Emergent Market of "Black Gold". *The Journal of Business and Industrial Marketing* **23**: 416–428.

Mulyanegara R, Tsarenko Y, Anderson A. 2009 The Big Five and Brand Personality: Investigating the Impact of Consumer Personality on Preferences Towards Particular Brand Personality. *Journal of Brand Management* **16**: 234–247.

National Center for Charitable Statistics. 2012. Retrieved September 10, 2012, from http://nccs.urban.org/statistics/quickfacts.cfm

Radley A, Kennedy M. 1995. Charitable Giving by Individuals: A Study of Attitudes and Practice. *Human Relations* **48** (6): 685–709

Roeger KL, Blackwood A, Pettijohn SL. 2011. The Nonprofit Sector in Brief, Public Charities, Giving, and Volunteering 2011. Trends from The Nonprofit Almanac 2011, Prepared by The National Center for Charitable Statistics at the Urban Institute. Retrieved September 9, 2012, from http://www.urban.org

Sargeant A. 1999. Charitable Giving: Towards a Model of Donor Behavior. *Journal of Marketing Management* **15**: 215–238.

Sargeant A, Ford J, Hudson J. 2008. Charity Brand Personality: The Relationship With Giving Behavior. *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly* **37**(3): 468–491.

Sargeant A, West D, Ford J. 2004. Does Perception Matter? An Empirical Analysis of Donor Behavior. *Service Industries Journal* **24**: 19–36.

Sargeant A, Woodliffe L. 2007. Gift Giving: An Interdisciplinary Review. *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing* **12**: 275–307.

Sirgy J. 1982. Self-Concept in Consumer Behavior: A Critical Review. *Journal of Consumer Research* **9**: 287–300.

Themudo NS. 2009. Gender and the Nonprofit Sector. *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly* **38**: 663–683.

Urban Institute Foundation. 2011. Retrieved September 9, 2012, from http://www.urban.org/nonprofits/index.cfm

Valenzi ER, Andrews IR. 1971. Effect of Price Information on Product Quality Ratings. *Journal of Applied Psychology* **55**: 87–91.

Venable B, Rose G, Bush V, Gilbert F. 2005. The Role of Brand Personality in Charitable Giving: An Assessment and Validation. *Academy of Marketing Science Journal* **33**(3): 295–316.

DOI: 10.1002/nvsm